

TIN WHISKERS

No, we are not talking about the Tin Man's mustach. Tin whiskers occur when not enough lead is used in solder. The ROHS standards will have you believe that lead is dangerous, and so it is, but a minimum of 3 per cent lead is required in all solder to prevent it from growing very fine "whiskers" over time. These can short out electronic circuits and considering that everything from cars and air-conditioners to camera lenses and motherboards use solder, this is a very serious issue indeed. Manufacturers are not too fastidious about this as not using lead, while also giving the illusion of being environmentally friendly, also guarantees that your product might short-circuit itself in about 7-10 years. If all goes as per plan, that is.



Kings or cattle? You decide

now, they've got nothing better to do, they're looking elsewhere, the masses gain some sort of morbid pleasure in seeing their idols fall and they are listening to these rebels. They are inexorably drifting away from us.

We need to get back control, we've gotten complacent and the cattle have gone unruly. When George Orwell wrote "1984", he wasn't too far off from the truth. That dystopian vision of the future is just what we need to ensure the survival of our race! Think about it, as someone once said, "A luxury once sampled, becomes a necessity." He was right, we went too far, gave these consumers too much. We must tone it down now, recondition them. They must not know that there is, or was, a possibility for a better life; a world where their car would last forever, a place where light bulbs will come with a 25 year warranty.

We must make them forget, the past didn't happen. The consumers themselves have made it easy for us. They want bigger, faster, better and all this without spending a rupee more than they feel like. We'll give them exactly that. They're not smart enough to care about

what is really important. What do they care if a laptop doesn't have an efficient cooling system or that there isn't enough lead in the solder? Tin Whiskers? Probably sounds like a funny Broadway play's take on the Wizard of Oz to them.

All they care about are the specifications and the price and whether they're getting a good deal. We just slap on a dual-core logo along with an ROHS compliant sticker and they'll be happy. They won't give a damn if the product fails because of overheating or short-circuits a year later, we'll just give them something else. Their minds will be so warped by the desire for something new that many of them will actually be happy that their product failed. Oh they will end up as permanently discontented individuals, always vying for the "next best thing" but why should we bother about that? They think they're happy and the psychiatrists will be happy for the business. Hell, we can sell them the drugs claiming to cure their "anxiety" and they'll thank us for it! We need to bring back their ravenous hunger for new products. Those mile long queues outside stores are what we

want to see again, that mindless passion for something new.

The Thailand floods were a nice starting point, at least we've managed to get hard disk prices under control. Give it a couple of years and they won't even remember the price hikes. We need something like these to kick start our sales and bring back the good old days. We still have the upper hand at the moment; those fools don't realise how much of their life we actually control. Almost every device they own is a ticking time bomb, just waiting to die. They don't wonder why aircraft don't fall out of the sky or why ATMs never stop working and we need to keep it that way. The market needs to be controlled, growth rate slowed down, we need to fix prices, postpone updates and refresh products that don't need to be refreshed. Give the consumers something new every year but always hint at something better to come. Entice them with the possibility of something seemingly spectacular. Tell them that the revolution is coming, that their life is going to change forever! We need to make backward compatibility a thing of the past. We must get back to our roots; planned obsolescence is the way to go. Let us resurrect the Phoebus cartel. They'll never understand anyway. Let them remain oblivious to the workings of their world. That is what they want, that is what we'll give them. F**k you, consumers; f**k you very much! ”

[Standing ovation and cheers]

PRINTER WASTE COUNTERS

Some resourceful hackers discovered that many printer models have a "kill switch" embedded in them. A small chip that keeps track of the number of pages being printed and which terminates printer function when a certain number is hit, usually 18,000. The printer might still be perfectly functional, but the chip will ensure that the printer cannot print anymore. There are some web sites which will help you reset this counter, but most of them will charge you a nominal fee for the tool. Hint: Use Google or whatever your favourite search engine is to search for your printer's "Waste counter reset tool".